

TOPIC 2: 16TH-18TH CENTURY PHILIPPINES

List of Reading Materials:

1. Customs of the Tagalogs
2. *Recopilacion de Leyes de los Reinos de las Indias*
3. *Historia de los Padres Dominicos en las Islas Filipinas y en sus Misiones del Japon, China, Tung-kin y Formosa*
4. *Historia General de Filipinas: Conquistas espirituales y temporales de estos españoles dominios, establecimientos progresos, y decadencias*
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INTRODUCTION FOR 16TH-18TH CENTURY PHILIPPINES

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The 16th to the 18th centuries under Spain are hereby encapsulated in ten excerpts coming from various documents written by Spaniards. The theme of the readings focus mainly on the situation of the Filipinos from the time of the early encounter until their actions towards the end of the 18th century which gave way to the different developments of the 19th. Although written by Spanish missionaries, the contents show the daily life and culture of the Filipinos during the Spanish colonial period.

The first is an excerpt of the Plasencia's Costumbres de los Tagalos which describe the different facets Tagalog everyday life. This is followed by a summarized translation of the laws regarding

the method of Reducción used in the New World and the Philippines. The third excerpt is a description made by Dominican missionaries on the Aetas in different parts of Luzon. This shows a general impression which could be duplicated as to how Filipinos were perceived by the Spaniards. The fourth excerpt is a brief account/anecdote on the conversion of Filipinos to Christianity. Readings five and six are from the Jesuit Pedro Chirino speaking about the daily life of the Tagalogs and their language. These show the efforts of the Spanish missionaries to understand the Filipinos and the complexity of the Filipinos' culture and society.

Reading seven is from the Practica del Ministerio of Tomas Ortiz describing some basic tenets of the prehispanic Philippine religion. The description shows the dynamics the conversion to Christianity as well as the everyday life of Filipinos engaging the missionaries. Readings eight, nine and ten are accounts of three rebellions starting among the datus of Tondo, to the rebellions of Tamblot and Bankaw in the Visayas until the Agricultural Revolt of 1745.

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Customs of the Tagalogs

Juan de Plasencia is a Franciscan friar who ministered in the Philippines from 1578 until his death in around 1590. Originally from Plasencia in Extremadura Spain, he is acknowledged as the founder of numerous towns in Luzon using the method of *reducción*. He also authored books on language and the famous Doctrina Cristiana published posthumously in 1593 and is the first book printed in the Philippines. The following is an excerpt of his long ethnography on the Tagalogs having been assigned in the Tagalog provinces of Bulacan, Laguna, Morong (Rizal) and Tayabas (Quezon). The reading discusses the social, political, economic and cultural setup of the Tagalogs at the period of early contact with the Spaniards. Plasencia documented the different social classes and their particular functions in the early Philippine society.

Excerpt:

This people always had chiefs, called by them *datos*, who governed them and were captains in their wars, and whom they obeyed and revered. The subject who committed any offense against them, or spoke but a word to their wives and children, was severely punished.

These Chiefs ruled over but few people; sometimes as many as a hundred houses, sometimes even less than thirty. This tribal gathering is called in *Tagalo* a *barangay*. It was inferred that the reason for giving themselves this name arose from the fact (as they are classed, by their language, among the Malay nations) that when they came to this land, the head of the *barangay*, which is a boat, thus called became a *dato*. And so, even at the present day, it is ascertained that this *barangay* in its origin was a family of parents and children, relations and slaves. There are many of these barangays in each town, or, at least, on account of war, they did not settle far from one another. They were not, however, subject to one another, except in

friendship and relationship. The chiefs, in their various wars, helped one another with their respective barangays.

In addition to chiefs, who corresponded to our knights, there were three castes: nobles, commoners and slaves. The nobles were the free-born whom they call *maharlica*. They did not pay tax or tribute to the *dato*, but must accompany him in war, at their own expense. The chief offered them beforehand a feast, and afterward they divided the spoils. Moreover, when the *dato* went upon the water those whom he summoned rowed for him. If he built a house, they helped him, and had to be fed for it. The same was true when the whole barangay went to clear up his lands for tillage. The lands which they inhabited were divided among the whole *barangay*, especially the irrigated portion, and thus each one knew his own. No one belonging to another *barangay* would cultivate them unless after purchase or inheritance. The lands of the *tingues*, or mountain ridges, are not divided, but owned in common by the *barangay*. Consequently, at the time of the rice harvest, any individual of any particular barangay, although he may have come

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from some other village, if he commences to clear any land may sow it, and no one can compel him to abandon it. There are some villages, as for example, Pila de la Laguna, which these nobles, or *maharlicas*, paid annually to the *dato* a hundred *gantas* of rice. The reason of this was that, at the time of their settlement there, another chief occupied the lands, which the new chief, upon his arrival, bought with his own gold; and therefore, the members of his *barangay* paid him for the land, and he divided it, among those whom he saw fit to reward. But now, since the advent of the Spaniards, it is not so divided.

The commoners are called *aliping namamahay*. They are married, and serve their master, whether he be a *dato* or not, with half of their cultivated lands, as was agreed upon in the beginning. They accompanied him whenever he went beyond the island, and rowed for him. They live in their own houses, and are lords of their property and gold. Their children inherit it, and enjoy their property and lands. The children, then, enjoy the rank of their father, and they cannot be made slave (*sa guiguilir*) nor can either parents or children be sold. If they should fall by inheritance into the hands of a son of their master who was going to dwell in another village, they could not be taken from their own village and carried with him; but they would remain in their native village, doing service there and cultivating the sowed lands.

The slaves are called *aliping sa guiguilir*. They serve their master in his house and on his cultivated lands, and may be sold. The master grants them, should he see fit, and providing that he has profited through their industry, a portion of their harvests, so that they may work faithfully. For these reasons, servants who are born in the house of their master are rarely, if ever, sold. That is the lot of captives in war, and of those brought up in the harvest fields.

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The following is an English translation of the original Spanish legislations found in the *Recopilacion de Leyes de los Reinos de las Indias* or the Laws of the Indies concerning the establishment of the *Reducciones*. The *Reducción* is the process of transferring the natives to a particular settlement. It was also used to designate the place where the settlement was established. The Recopilacion is a compilation of the different laws promulgated by the Queen or the King of Spain and were legislated to guide the Spaniards in the colonies as to their behavior towards the natives. It was first released as a compilation in 1680 under King Carlos II. The legislation below can be found in Book VI, Title III and provided guidelines for the establishment of towns or pueblos. The copies of the laws were said to have been provided and translated by Zelia Nuttall (1857-1933), an American anthropologist specializing in Aztec-Mexican cultures. The legislations are of importance to the Philippines since these are the same legislations used in the establishment of the towns until the 19th century, immediately before the Revolution of 1896. It thus created a new landscape besides the social and economic changes throughout the period of Spanish colonization.

Excerpt:

On arriving at the locality where the new settlement is to be founded, the plan of the place, with its squares, streets and building lots is to be outlined by means of measuring by cord and ruler, beginning with the main square from which streets are to run to the gates and principal roads and leaving sufficient open space so that even if the town grows it can always spread in a symmetrical manner. Having thus laid out the chosen site the settlement is to be founded the following form.

The chosen site shall be on an elevation; healthful; with means of fortification; fertile and with plenty of land for farming and pasturage; fuel and timber; fresh water, a native population, commodiousness; resources of convenient access and egress. It shall be open to the north wind. If on the coast, care is to be taken that the sea does not lie to the south or west of the harbor. If possible, the port is not to be near lagoons or marshes in which poisonous animals and corruption of air and water breed.

In the case of a sea coast town, the main plaza is to be the starting point for the building of the town, is to be situated near the landing place of the port. In inland towns the main plaza should be in the center of the town and of an oblong shape, its length being equal to at least one and half times its width, as this proportion is best for festivals in which horses are used and any other celebrations which have to be held.

The size of the plaza shall be in proportion to the number of residents, heed being given to the fact that towns of Indians, being new are bound to grow and it is intended that they shall

do so. Therefore, the plaza is to be planned with reference to the possible growth of the town. It shall not be smaller than two hundred feet wide and three hundred feet long nor larger than eight hundred feet long and three hundred feet wide. A well proportionated medium size plaza is not six hundred feet long and four hundred feet wide.

From the plaza, the four principal streets are to diverge, one from the middle of each of its sides and two streets are to meet at each of its corners. The four corners of the plaza are to face the four points of the compass, because thus the streets diverging from the plaza will not be directly exposed to the four principal winds, which could cause much inconvenience.

The whole plaza and the four main streets diverging from it shall have arcades, for these are a great convenience for those who resort thither for trade. The eight streets which run into the plaza at its four corners are to do so freely without being obstructed by the arcades of the plaza. These arcades are to end at the corners in such a way that the sidewalks of the streets can evenly join those of the plaza.

In cold climates, the streets shall be wide; in hot climates narrow, however, for purposes of defense and where horses are kept the streets had better be wide.

The other streets laid out consecutively around the plaza are to be so planned that even if the town should increase considerably in size it would meet with no obstruction which might disfigure what had already been built or be a detriment to the defense or convenience of the town.

At certain distances in the town smaller, well proportion plazas are to be laid out on which the main church, the parish church or monastery shall be built so that the teaching of religious doctrine may be evenly distributed.

If the town lies on the coast, its main church shall be so situated that it may be visible from the landing place and so built that its structure may serve as means of defense for the port itself.

After the plaza and streets have been laid out building lots are to be designated, in the first place, for the erection of the main church, the parish church or monastery and these are to occupy respectively an entire block so that no other structure can be built next to them excepting such as contribute to their commodiousness or beauty.

Immediately afterwards the place and site are to be assigned for the Royal and Town Council House, the Custom House and Arsenal which is to be close to the church and port so that in case of necessity one can protect the other. The hospital for the poor and sick of non contagious diseases shall be built next to the church forming its cloister.

Historia de los Padres Dominicos en las Islas Filipinas y en sus Misiones del Japon, China, Tung-kin y Formosa

The following excerpt is from the *Noticias Preliminares* (Preliminary Notes) of the six volume work by the Dominicans Juan Ferrando and Joaquin Fonseca titled *Historia de los Padres Dominicos en las Islas Filipinas y en sus Misiones del Japon, China, Tung-kin y Formosa* published from 1870-1872. The section contains ethnographic descriptions of the Spaniards in the Philippines, the Chinese migrants, the Mestizos, the lowland natives as well as the different northern peoples like the Tinguians, Igorots and Ilongots. Also included are the Negritos from the different parts of Luzon. The main author, Juan Ferrando, O.P. arrived in the Philippines around 1842 and was assigned to Vigan as companion to the Bishop Rafael Masoliver. He is described as more clear, concise and methodic of the Dominican historians of the Philippines. Utilized in this excerpt were the writings of historians like Diego Aduarte, O.P. and Francisco Antolin, O.P. He was able to finish the *Historia* to include the events until the year 1840. His unpublished work was later edited by Joaquin Fonseca, O.P. who added an appendix bringing the work down to the year 1871. Below is a part of the English translation by Jose Rhommel B. Hernandez and published in 1994 containing the description of the “Negros” and as later on labeled in the text itself, the Aetas.

Excerpt:

Not only in Luzon, but also in the Visayas can be found the true oceanic blacks which form an entirely different race from the rest known in the discovered world. In the Philippines, they are known by the Spaniards as the “Negritos,” and by the natives, as Aetas, Itas, Etas, Balugas, etc., according to the provinces in whose surroundings they live. They are very likely the first inhabitants of the country. In nothing are they similar to those of the Malay race in the divisions, color, hair, customs and mode living. Even their dialect is distinct from that which the nations coming from their caste speak. Many of the like those who go down to the towns speak the idiom of the Indios. Many doubt if they have a proper idiom. In their dances, however, they sing in an unintelligible manner and many seem to howl rather than sing. In their hair, not all are equals. Some tribes have it somewhat straight, but they are generally curly, like those who come from Africa, although not so dark. The color of the body is so dark, much more than that of the natives of the Malay race. They have their mouths broader than the ordinary, and more distant from the nose, which is small and grounded in some. Almost all have side burns and some have beard. Their clothing is made of a miserable girdle which covers their shame. The women, when going to the Christian towns cover their breasts with another piece of cloth made of cotton or valet bark. They are of very limited intelligence, although in some can be discovered signs indicating more than the regular talent, if they will be cultivated. Their race can be called as the ultimate of the human species. Their physique has all the characters of a savage and degraded race. They themselves have an idea so low of themselves that they say that they are not men nor people, but

Aetas. They live within the forests in the ranges of the west of Manila Bay, from Mariveles until Pangasinan; in the slopes of one and another side, from that which crosses the island from the east to west from San Fabian until Valer; to the west of some towns of Cagayan, and in the other ranges from the Cape of Engaño until Tayabas; in the mountains of San Mateo and Camachin; in some parts of the provinces of the South; in a word, they are in almost all the mountains of Luzon, grouped in small tribes with relations between themselves, particularly the neighbors of a same range. They do not have any dwelling other than bad huts under the trees and at time some entangled branches to avoid in some way the effect of bad weather. Most of them sleep where the night seizes them, and when they are cold, or the humidity is very great, they burn bonfires and they turn themselves over on hot ashes. They are not dedicated to agriculture and are maintained from wild roots, leaves of trees and cattles that by chance opens itself to an arrow shot. They suffer much on rainy days, and days passed without them taking anything other than herb. For the hunting of the wild boar, or wild hogs, they have some arrows whose iron points are held with a cane by means of some strong small cords. The arrows are released to enter into the body of the wild beast, which afterwards remains in the thickets and the hunter is easily freed from its fangs, which is known to cause terrible wounds. Their government consists in leaving each one in a more complete liberty, and in the observance of some practices inherited from their old one. One of them is the eating in common large cattle gathered by some of them. There is no sign of religion found among them, as they may not be some practices indicating their belief in the immortality of the soul. Their matrimonies are solemnized with some brute feasts that do not merit the hardship of being narrated. The essential ceremony consists in making an old woman nod at those engaged, saying sometimes the following expressions: "Produce the man, produce the woman", very proper to designate the primary end of the marriage, in which they differ hardly from the beasts. In some points they themselves go around burning notably, as happens in the mountains of Bataan, an effect of the miserable life they live. They lack women, since the Tagalog Indias hire many of them to their service. These women are mixed at times with the Indios, and the Mestizos who are born from them do not have curly hair. There is someone saying that their feature is better than that of the Tagalog.

Those who live in the surroundings of the Christian towns are voluntary slaves. For a little rice or other trifle, they cross from great distance wax, wood, canes and reeds. All have their patrons, who give them lodging when they go down to the towns. This benefit is not little favor considering the disgust that is in their uncovered bodies, covered regularly from the hips and groins. From the conversion of the natives of the islands which the missionaries began, they also thought of converting the people of this degraded caste. But nobody until now has been able to boast of have subjected and united a tribe for a long time to show them the civil and Christian life.

Historia General de Filipinas: Conquistas espirituales y temporales de estos españoles dominios, establecimientos progresos, y decadencias

Juan de la Concepcion is a Recollect missionary known for his monumental 14 volume work *Historia General de Filipinas: Conquistas espirituales y temporales de estos españoles dominios, establecimientos progresos, y decadencias*. The work was published from 1788 until 1792. The following excerpt narrates a certain Fray Rodrigo's experience in working with the Filipinos near Bagumbayan which was then a highly forested area. The brief anecdote is a rich source of the possible transitions happening in the minds of the Filipinos in their reception of Christianity.

Excerpt:

Father Fray Rodrigo was one day passing through a thicket. That thicket was, according to their customs, one of the reserved ones, and it was considered sacrilegious to cut anything from it, and that such act would be punished with immediate death. So infatuated were they with that blindness that no one, even though in great need, dared to take anything from that place, being restrained by fear. The Father saw a beautiful tree, which they call *pajo*, laden with ripe fruit. He ordered his followers to gather some by climbing the tree. They strenuously resisted, but Father Fray Rodrigo insisted on it. They declared that they would not do it under any circumstances, and that it meant sure death if they offended the respect whose fatal sentence comprehended all the trees of that place. The Father severely chided them for their error, and to show them that it was so, he determined to gather fruit himself. He began to break branches and to clear the trunk, in order to facilitate the ascent. The Indians were grieved, and urgently begged him to desist from that undertaking which they considered as so rash. But the religious, arming himself with the sign of the cross, and reciting the antiphon, *Ecce lignum crucis*, managed to gather some of the ripe fruit, which the tree offered. He ate it in front of them and liked the fruit very much, for indeed it is savory. They looked at his face amazed, expecting his instant death. When that did not happen, they recognized their delusion and detested their cheats. They also ate without experiencing any harm. The Father charged them to say nothing upon their arrival at the village. He took with him a goodly quantity of that fruit and divided the great portion of it among the chiefs. Esteeming the gift, they, in their ignorance, ate it without fear. In a sermon on the following day, the Father disclosed the secret and checked their vain fears; so that, undeceived by experience, they followed him with their axes, and in short order felled that thicket, which was a confused center of perverse iniquities. Thereupon, many of those infidels submitted to the true knowledge.

Relacion de las Islas Filipinas

The author of the following excerpts is the Jesuit Fr. Pedro Chirino. He first arrived in the

Philippines as a young priest in 1590 and was assigned to Balayan and later on to Taytay in the following year 1591. He studied the Tagalog language and was one of the first missionaries to deliver sermons in that language. His masterpiece is his *Relacion de las Islas Filipinas* which was published in Rome in 1604. The two excerpts shows the status of the Tagalogs in the early years of the Spanish contact particularly their everyday life and language.

Excerpt:

The Filipinos are not so ceremonious in their actions as are the Chinese and Japanese; yet they have their politeness and good breeding, especially the Tagalos, who are very civil and courteous in word and action. Upon meeting one another, they practice our custom of uncovering the head--not that they used hats, caps, or bonnets; but they wore a piece of cloth like a towel, some three or four palmos long, which they wound around the head in becoming fashion, like the ancient crowns or diadems. This they removed, as they now do the hat [sombrero]--which they have adopted, in imitation of us, abandoning the potong, as they called the towel or diadem which they formerly wore. As among them it is not courtesy to remain standing before a person whom they respect, they seat themselves upon the ground, or rather on their heel-bones. Seated in this way, with head uncovered and the potong thrown like a towel over the left shoulder, they talk with their superiors. The mode of salutation upon entering or meeting anyone is as follows: They draw the body together and make a low reverence, raising one or both hands to the face, and placing them upon the cheeks; they next sit down waiting for the question that may be put to them, for it is considered bad manners to speak before one is spoken to. Their greatest courtesy is in their form of address; for they never speak to one as "thou," or in the second person, whether singular or plural, but always use the third person, saying for example--"Does the lord, or the chief, wish for this or that?" There are many examples of this to be found in Holy Scripture or sacred language, and particularly in the Psalms. In the relations of man with woman, woman with man, or woman with woman, they are very careful--even when they are quite equals, and, too, among the middle class--to use, after every important word, nothing but "my Lord," or "my Lady;" as, "My Lord, as I was coming up the river, I saw, my Lord," etc. This term and pronoun are used as agreeable and even affectionate, even in the languages of much greater importance, as Hebrew, Greek, and Latin, which are the three most venerable tongues. In polite and affectionate intercourse, they are very extravagant, addressing letters to each other in terms of elaborate and delicate expressions of affection, and neat turns of thought. As a result of this, they are much given to musical practice; and although the guitar that they use, called cutyapi, is not very ingenious or rich in tone, it is by no means disagreeable, and to them is most pleasing. They play it with such vivacity and skill that they seem to make human voices issue from its four metallic cords. We also have it on good authority that by merely playing these instruments they

can, without opening their lips, communicate with one another, and make themselves perfectly

understood--a thing unknown of any other nation. The Bisayans are more rustic and less civil in manners, just as their language is harsher and less polished. They have not so many terms of courtesy, as formerly they had no letters until, a very few years ago, they borrowed theirs from the Tagalos. As we have already treated of their languages, it would be advisable to make some mention of their letters.